

Precious Little

MINISTRY OF MINES

Staff: 13,316

Wages and allowances: Rs 210.03 crore

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: Rs 389.7 crore

RATIONALE: Survey and exploration of all minerals (other than natural gas and petroleum), mining and metallurgy of non-ferrous metals and administration of the Mines and Minerals Act, 1957, in respect of all mines and minerals, other than coal, natural gas and petroleum.

REALITY CHECK: In the federal structure of India, the states are the owners of minerals located within their boundaries and thus the authority on clearances for mining concessions. A ministry just for issuing concessions for minerals in India's territorial waters is not justified.

India is endowed with significant mineral resources. It produces 89 minerals, out of which four are fuel minerals, 11 metallic, 52 non-metallic and 22 minor minerals. Eighty-five per cent of these are mined by PSUs. The Geological Survey of India has mapped an area of approximately 3.146 million sq km, or 94 per cent of the area of India. So we know what we have, where it is and who owns it. Hundred per cent foreign direct investment is permissible for exploration and exploitation of all non-fuel and non-atomic minerals, including gold and silver. FDI up to 74 per cent is permitted in precious stones and diamonds. But it isn't

as if there is a rush of investors at Shastri Bhavan. Nor is there any great buzz amongst investors about the opportunity in India. That is because the system is layered with controls. An application for mining concession by Tata Steel in 2004 is among the 93 approvals pending with the ministry.

Its track record in resource utilisation is pathetic. Despite allocations being halved from Rs 8,344.5 crore to Rs 4,485.28 crore, total expenditure during the first four years of the Tenth Plan was Rs 2,042.95 crore, or less than 50 per cent of the revised plan outlay. To enable speedier clearances, it is best to de-layer the system. States should be responsible for mines in their territory and the Centre could institute a regulatory authority for clearances.



Self Goal

MINISTRY OF YOUTH & SPORTS AFFAIRS

Staff: 192

Wages and allowances: Rs 65.18 crore

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: Rs 613.44 crore

RATIONALE: To harness the potential of the youth of the country and involve them in nation-building; create facilities and promote capacity building for broad-basing sports.

REALITY CHECK: Promotion of sports is primarily the responsibility of the national sports federations. The ministry's role is that of an exchequer. And considering that half the populace is under 20 years of age, the need for a Ministry of Youth Affairs is debatable.

The Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports was initially set up as the Department of Sports in 1982 at the time of organisation of the IX Asian Games in Delhi. It was rechristened Department of Youth Affairs and Sports during the celebration of the International Youth Year in 1985, and came to be a ministry only on May 27, 2000. But beyond its role in organising the Asian Games and now its looming presence in the confusion preceding the 2010 Commonwealth Games, the ministry has little to show for its existence. Especially if you go by India's Olympics medals tally since 1984, which is a grand total of three.

Promotion of sports may be the responsibility of federations, but the ministry, which may itself be a victim of cross-party political linkages of sports administrators, cannot escape the fact that it has failed to bring slack federations in line. With a shoestring budget—which is gobbled up by canny federation experts for promoting dubious coaching camps and overseas junkets—there is little the ministry can do even in terms of capacity creation other than support bids for major events.

As for its role in promoting youth activities, the Standing Committee of Parliament has criticised the ministry's inability to achieve desired results and for "injudiciously" launching new schemes, not allocating funds for old ones and underutilising allocations. Clearly the unspent balances of various schemes indicate that the very idea of the ministry is out of tune with modern times.

